

RUAN MACHADO

Affiliate & Commercial Leader | iGaming & Performance Marketing • Partnerships • Channel Growth & P&L | Scaled an affiliate network 0→1,000+ partners, 500 FTDs/day

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EXPERIENCE

Head of Affiliates and Marketing

Grupo Santa Aposta

📅 01/2024 - Present 📍 São Paulo, Brazil

Santa Aposta is an affiliate network focused on the Brazilian iGaming market, acting as a bridge between licensed operators and performance affiliates.

My role covers both sides of that equation and both sides of the business model.

- Structured and scaled Santa Aposta's affiliate network from scratch to over 1,000 active affiliates, reaching a peak of 500 FTDs per day.
- Recruitment, onboarding, program structure, commission models (CPA, RevShare, Hybrid), and ongoing relationship management with top-performing partners.
- Managed and commercialized Santa Aposta's own media assets as an affiliate channel.
- Analyzed LTV and churn by traffic origin to identify which affiliates bring players who stay and which ones bring cost disguised as results.
- Monitored fraud patterns in affiliate traffic by cross-referencing player behavior data with campaign origin to catch inconsistencies before they become problems.
- Integrated the affiliate channel with operator CRM strategy for better acquisition and retention alignment.
- Structured joint planning, communication compliance, and campaign alignment within Brazil's regulated market.
- Led the network's marketing initiatives, including activations with influencers, athletes, and clubs within the Brazilian iGaming context.
- Built and led the full affiliate operation for a betting operator that had no in-house affiliate arm — Santa Aposta acted as their outsourced, extended affiliate team, and I led it end to end: recruitment, deal structure, performance, and CRM integration.

iGaming Content & Acquisition

Blaze

📅 06/2023 - 12/2023 📍 Brazil

Ran content and SEO for an iGaming operator with one objective: acquire players. Coordinated a team of writers and worked directly with CRM to align content with player acquisition and retention — not just publishing volume.

Built the SEO and content strategy behind organic acquisition.

- 35% growth in organic traffic
- 500+ articles published

Founder

DSC MKT

📅 08/2020 - 06/2023 📍 Salvador, Brazil

- Founded and ran a 360° marketing agency
- Operated the digital acquisition, sales, and performance channels for 20+ client companies
- Owned the full cycle: winning clients, running their performance, and managing the agency end to end
- 80% of the client portfolio was later acquired by an agency group

SUMMARY

I built Grupo Santa Aposta's affiliate network from zero to 1,000+ active affiliates, with a peak of 500 FTDs/day, in Brazil's regulated iGaming market. What I do: I run affiliate acquisition and commercial operations end to end — recruitment, onboarding, deal negotiation (CPA, RevShare, Hybrid), and channel P&L — and I manage it by player quality, not click volume.

The difference is data. Most affiliate channels are managed on relationship and gut feel. I manage mine on LTV and churn by traffic origin, fraud detection in affiliate traffic, and CRM integration between acquisition and retention.

That's how a channel stops being a cost center and starts being a margin.

I also operate Santa Aposta's own media assets as an affiliate channel — so I sit on both sides of the performance equation: I manage affiliates and I am one. Track record:-
0 → 1,000+ active affiliates-
Peak 500 FTDs/day-
CPA / RevShare / Hybrid models, structured and negotiated

CERTIFICATIONS

High-Performance Leadership: Lessons from Formula 1®

Santander Open Academy

Sales Executive — Consultative Selling & Prospecting

FIA Business School

[Official] Spark Workshop - CRM Strategies for iGaming

Fast Track

Vibe Coding

LOVABLE

EDUCATION

Bacharelado, Marketing

Centro Universitário Belas Artes de São Paulo

 01/2022 - 12/2024